

Rerun of the MTA Provider Analysis for Outbound SMTP Port 25

Executive summary

The attached file is a research prompt, not a completed provider decision. It clearly assumes a self-managed MTA design that needs a host with a stable public IP, reverse-DNS/PTR capability, and the ability to reach remote SMTP on port 25, but it does **not** specify a budget, target region, or mandatory compliance baseline beyond asking that those factors be assessed. [filecite turn0file0](#)

The main result of this rerun is that the strongest currently documented options for **direct outbound SMTP over port 25** are no longer just “AWS or Hetzner.” The clearest, loosest current public documentation I found is from **Scaleway**: for public cloud Instances, outbound SMTP ports 25, 465, and 587 are blocked by default, but after identity verification they can be enabled in the security-group workflow; for Elastic Metal, the same ports can be enabled per availability zone in-console after identity verification. That is materially lower-friction than the ticket-and-wait workflows used by most peers. **AWS EC2** remains viable, but the official EC2 documentation still frames port 25 removal as a request-based exception rather than a default capability. **Hetzner Cloud** is still attractive on cost and simplicity, but it requires account aging plus a first paid invoice before a case-by-case unblocking request. **Akamai Cloud** is also viable, but only after a 30-day account-aging period and support review. **Azure** can be permissive if you are already on the right enterprise subscription type; otherwise it is restrictive. **Google Cloud** and **DigitalOcean** remain poor fits for direct-to-MX delivery if port 25 is a hard requirement. ¹

A second result is architectural rather than provider-specific: even where port 25 is available, the provider’s abuse posture is telling you something important. Providers that make port 25 easy to use usually still expect strong identity verification, abuse handling, and reputation hygiene. The cloud-platform trend is toward **authenticated relay on 587** or a managed relay service, because that reduces abuse, protects IP reputation, and improves deliverability. In other words, the right decision is not only “who will open port 25,” but “how much operational email reputation work do you actually want to own.” ²

What the attached file actually requires

The attached file asks for a provider comparison that is explicitly centered on self-hosting an MTA, comparing options such as AWS, GCP, Azure, DigitalOcean, Hetzner, OVHcloud, and others against criteria such as static IP support, SMTP egress, reverse DNS, deliverability considerations, abuse risk, and migration effort. It also asks for security, compliance, and support considerations to be included. What it does **not** specify is equally important: there is no committed budget ceiling, no mandated geography, no required throughput or daily message volume, and no fixed compliance framework that would force a particular vendor. [filecite turn0file0](#)

That means the practical decision should be driven by four implementation questions, not by brand familiarity alone. First, do you truly need **raw direct-to-MX delivery** on port 25, or would a relay-based design on port 587 satisfy the use case? Second, how much **approval friction** can you tolerate before cutover? Third, how much **email reputation work** will you take on internally? Fourth, do you need a provider with broad global geography and enterprise procurement alignment, or would a regional cloud with simpler SMTP enablement be better? Those questions are the difference between choosing AWS or Azure for ecosystem reasons, versus choosing Scaleway or Hetzner because they are operationally simpler for this exact workload.   3

Provider comparison

The table below is intentionally decision-oriented. It emphasizes what matters most for this workload: whether remote port 25 is realistically usable, how much effort is required to get there, and whether the provider’s documentation is clear enough to trust during implementation.

Provider	Region availability	Port 25 posture	Approval friction	Cost, support, and compliance notes	Migration fit
Scaleway Instances	Region-based public-cloud footprint with AZ-aware controls; the SMTP workflow is explicitly AZ-specific, and the public site publishes a product-by-region matrix. 	Public docs say remote SMTP ports 25, 465, and 587 are blocked by default to prevent spam, but after KYC you can tick Enable SMTP in the security group and apply it immediately. 	Low to medium. Identity verification is required, but the action is largely self-service once the account is eligible. 	Strongest support transparency of the non-hyperscalers reviewed: Basic is free; Advanced starts at €50 or 5% of spend; Business starts at €250 or 10%; Enterprise starts at €990 or 20%. Trust-center capture surfaced GDPR, HDS, and ISO/IEC 27001. 	Best current operational fit if direct port 25 matters and you want clearer enablement than AWS/Akamai/Hetzner.

Provider	Region availability	Port 25 posture	Approval friction	Cost, support, and compliance notes	Migration fit
Scaleway Elastic Metal	Bare-metal cloud with AZ-based SMTP enablement; public site lists Elastic Metal as a separate product family. ⁷	Docs say SMTP ports 25, 465, and 587 are closed by default, then can be enabled per Availability Zone in the console after identity verification. ⁸	Low to medium. Similar KYC requirement, but still more predictable than support-ticket exception processes. ⁸	Same Scaleway support and trust posture as above; no exact Elastic Metal starter price was exposed in the captured static text, but the product family is marketed as “flexible pricing.” ⁹	Excellent if you want dedicated hardware, stronger isolation, or tighter control over reputation-sensitive workloads.
AWS EC2	AWS currently states that its cloud spans 123 Availability Zones within 39 Regions. ¹⁰	EC2 allows outbound port 25 only to private IPv4 addresses by default; public IPv4 and IPv6 port 25 traffic is blocked unless you request removal of the restriction. ¹¹	Medium. Official docs say you can request removal, but the primary EC2 page does not publish a deterministic approval rubric. ¹¹	EC2 remains highly flexible on cost model: on-demand hourly or per-second billing with no long-term commitment. AWS’s infrastructure page also emphasizes strong security and compliance posture. ¹²	Best hyperscaler fit if you need enterprise maturity and broad region choice, and you can tolerate request-based enablement.

Provider	Region availability	Port 25 posture	Approval friction	Cost, support, and compliance notes	Migration fit
Hetzner Cloud	Hetzner lists locations in Germany, Finland, Singapore, and U.S. sites in Ashburn and Hillsboro. ¹³	Hetzner says it blocks ports 25 and 465 by default on all cloud servers; after one month and a paid first invoice, you can request unblocking for a valid use case; port 587 is not blocked. ¹⁴	Medium. Easier than many large clouds, but still gated by account age, payment history, and case-by-case review. ¹⁵	Public capture confirms GDPR rights and ISO 27001:2022 certification for core data-center operations. Numeric cloud starter pricing was not reliably exposed in the static capture, although Hetzner markets the cloud line as low-cost and provides a calculator. ¹⁶	Very good value fit for a cost-sensitive self-hosted MTA if you can wait through the trust-building period.

Provider	Region availability	Port 25 posture	Approval friction	Cost, support, and compliance notes	Migration fit
Akamai Cloud	Akamai's core-compute matrix lists a broad set of regions including Amsterdam, Chennai, Chicago, Frankfurt, London, Los Angeles, Mumbai, Newark, Osaka, Paris, São Paulo, Seattle, Singapore, Stockholm, Sydney, Tokyo, Toronto, and Washington, DC, plus distributed-compute regions. ¹⁷	Akamai's email guide states that outbound SMTP port 25 is restricted on new accounts and that removal can be requested only after the account is older than 30 days and billing information is current. ¹⁸	Medium. Clearer than AWS about timing, but still gated by account age and support review. ¹⁸	Pricing is unusually transparent: a 1 GB shared plan starts at US\$5/month , and Managed Service is US\$100 per compute instance per month . Support is 24-hour via ticket, phone, or email, with tickets as the primary method. Detailed compliance controls existed behind Akamai's trust portal, but they were not retrievable in text form during this run. ¹⁹	Good alternative if you want a broad footprint and can accept the 30-day waiting period.

Provider	Region availability	Port 25 posture	Approval friction	Cost, support, and compliance notes	Migration fit
Azure VMs and Azure Firewall	Azure maintains a global geography/region footprint. ²⁰	For standard Enterprise Agreement and MCA-E subscriptions, Azure says outbound SMTP on TCP 25 is not blocked for VMs and Azure Firewall. Enterprise Dev/Test is blocked by default but can be exempted through the portal diagnostic workflow. All other subscription types are blocked on TCP 25. Azure also notes limited PaaS exceptions such as App Service and Functions through VNet integration or ASE v3. ²¹	Low if you already have the right subscription; high otherwise. The gating factor is commercial subscription type more than technical capability. ²²	Azure strongly recommends authenticated SMTP relay on port 587 and points to Azure Communication Services; default relay rate limits can be raised with a support case. Linux VM pricing remains usage-based and region/SKU dependent. ²³	Conditional fit. Strong choice only if you already live in Azure EA/MCA-E.

Provider	Region availability	Port 25 posture	Approval friction	Cost, support, and compliance notes	Migration fit
Google Cloud Compute Engine	Google Cloud publishes a global locations footprint. ²⁴	Google says 587 and 465 have no restrictions to external IPs, but external destination TCP 25 is blocked for most projects. It also notes that some projects do not have this restriction. ²⁵	High. The default posture is restrictive, and direct-to-MX depends on project-specific exceptions you may not control. ²⁶	Google's own guidance pushes you toward SendGrid, Mailgun, Mailjet, Google Workspace relay on 465/587, a custom non-standard port, or even VPN to a corporate mail server. Pricing is usage-based and billed per second after a 1-minute minimum. Google also flags Workspace email-activity limits. ²⁷	Poor fit for raw port-25 MTA hosting unless you already know the project is exempt.

Provider	Region availability	Port 25 posture	Approval friction	Cost, support, and compliance notes	Migration fit
DigitalOcean Droplets	DigitalOcean has a broad multi-region cloud footprint and standard Droplet pricing, but that does not change the SMTP restriction. ²⁸	Current docs are blunt: SMTP ports 25, 465, and 587 are blocked on Droplets by default, including through Reserved IPs. DigitalOcean recommends using a third-party email service provider instead of self-hosting mail. ²⁹	Very high. In practical terms, there is no attractive direct-to-MX path in the current public documentation. ²⁹	Trust Platform states SOC 2, SOC 3, Global PRP, and eligibility for HIPAA and DORA workloads. Those trust features do not offset the SMTP limitation for this use case. ³⁰	Not recommended if outbound port 25 is a hard requirement.

Provider profiles

Best current candidates for direct-to-MX delivery

Scaleway Instances are the most important new finding in this rerun. Their documentation does not treat SMTP enablement like a special one-off support exception; instead, it treats it as a guarded but operational feature. The docs say remote SMTP ports 25, 465, and 587 are blocked by default “to prevent spam,” but after KYC the operator can enable SMTP in the security group for the relevant availability zone, and the setting is applied immediately to the affected Instances. That combination — identity verification plus a fairly direct control-plane action — is unusually friendly for this workload. Scaleway also publishes unusually explicit support-plan pricing and exposes a trust-center footprint that includes GDPR, HDS, and ISO/IEC 27001 in the captured page. ³¹

Scaleway Elastic Metal is the adjacent “higher control” option. The Elastic Metal documentation says outbound SMTP ports 25, 465, and 587 are “closed” by default and then can be enabled per availability zone in the console after identity verification. If your mail workload is reputation-sensitive or you want stronger isolation than a shared VM gives you, Elastic Metal is a serious option. The tradeoff is migration complexity: moving an MTA stack from a generic VM to a bare-metal host is rarely difficult at the software layer, but it usually changes your backup, observability, recovery, and scaling assumptions. ³²

AWS EC2 remains the safest mainstream enterprise answer, but not the most frictionless one. AWS’s EC2 documentation is straightforward that outbound port 25 to public IPv4 and IPv6 destinations is blocked by

default, while private IPv4 remains allowed. The same page says you can request removal of the restriction. Combined with AWS's very large region footprint, mature support channels, and flexible on-demand pricing, that keeps EC2 near the top of the shortlist. The reason I would rank it slightly behind Scaleway for this exact use case is simply that the primary AWS documentation still frames port 25 as an exception request rather than an account-level feature with an explicit enablement workflow. ³³

Hetzner Cloud remains compelling when cost discipline matters and the workload can wait through initial trust-building. Hetzner's docs say it blocks ports 25 and 465 by default, and that only after a month plus the first paid invoice can you submit a limit request for a valid use case; decisions are case by case. The same doc also says port 587 is not blocked. That is stricter than Scaleway's self-service model, but still clearer and often cheaper than hyperscaler exception processes. Compliance-wise, Hetzner's public material supports ISO 27001:2022 for core facilities and references GDPR rights clearly. ³⁴

Akamai Cloud is the other meaningful addition from this rerun. Its cloud-email guidance states that outbound SMTP port 25 is restricted on new accounts and that requests to lift those restrictions are considered only after the account is older than 30 days and billing details are current. That puts Akamai in the same broad category as Hetzner — trust-building first, exception second — but with a much larger geography matrix exposed in the captured docs and unusually transparent compute pricing. The main gap is that Akamai's trust/compliance portal existed but was not text-retrievable in this run, so I would verify any required audit artifact directly before procurement. ³⁵

Conditional options

Azure is more nuanced than many teams assume. The current Microsoft article says outbound TCP 25 is **not blocked** for VMs and Azure Firewall in standard Enterprise Agreement and MCA-E subscriptions. It also says Enterprise Dev/Test subscriptions are blocked by default but can be automatically exempted through the Diagnose and Solve workflow in the Azure portal. That is much better than a blanket "Azure blocks SMTP" narrative — but only if you are already on the right commercial plan. For most other subscription types, the platform blocks outbound TCP 25 and recommends authenticated relay on port 587, including Azure Communication Services. In practice, Azure is a good answer for organizations already standardized on enterprise Azure procurement; it is not a universally easy answer for everyone else. ³⁶

Google Cloud Compute Engine is still a weak fit for direct-to-MX delivery. Google's current documentation is explicit that ports 587 and 465 are unrestricted to external IPs, while external destination port 25 is blocked for most projects because of abuse risk, though some projects do not have that restriction. The rest of the page steers users toward partner relays, Google Workspace relay, non-standard ports, or VPN back to a corporate mail environment. That makes GCP operationally fine for relay-based sending, but unreliable as a procurement target when what you really need is guaranteed direct external port 25 egress. ³⁷

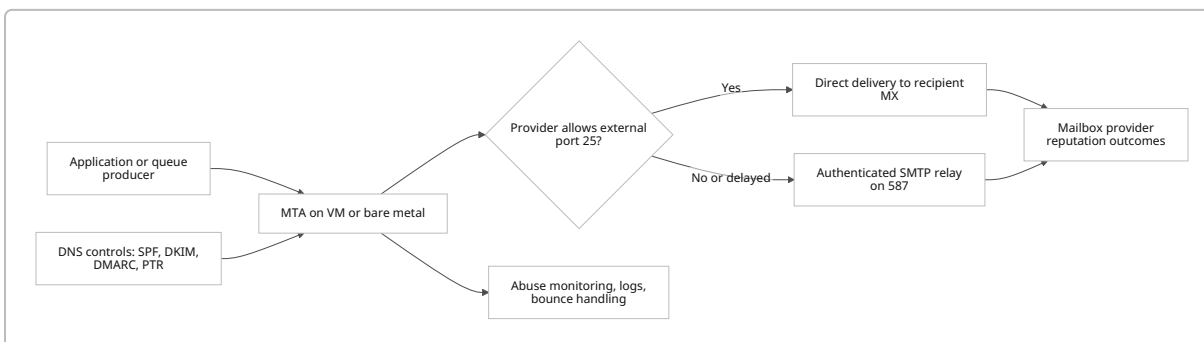
Poor fits for this requirement

DigitalOcean is the clearest negative case. The current support article says SMTP ports 25, 465, and 587 are blocked on Droplets by default, including traffic through Reserved IPs, and then explicitly recommends using a third-party email service provider instead of self-hosting mail. DigitalOcean may still be the right place for apps that relay through a managed mail service, but it is the wrong answer if your design requirement is truly "my VM must speak raw SMTP on port 25 to remote MXs." ²⁹

Security, abuse, and migration implications

The providers' documentation points to the same underlying truth: port 25 is restricted because it is a high-abuse surface, and the operational burden does not end when a provider opens it. Google explicitly ties the block to abuse risk and pushes trusted relays and custom ports. Azure explicitly recommends authenticated SMTP relay and frames relay partly as a way to protect IP reputation and delivery reliability. DigitalOcean goes further and strongly recommends against running your own mail server. Hetzner explains its block as anti-spam trust-building. Those are not just policy annoyances; they are warnings about what you inherit if you insist on raw port 25. ³⁸

The security tradeoff is therefore straightforward. The **loosest** providers reduce your approval friction, but they also make it easier for you to shoulder the full deliverability burden: PTR/rDNS hygiene, SPF/DKIM/DMARC, queue controls, bounce and complaint processing, IP warm-up, volume shaping, and monitoring for abuse. The **most restrictive** providers raise your implementation friction, but they also nudge you toward a more abuse-resistant design based on authenticated relays and managed reputation. For most teams, the technically safest design is to keep raw direct-to-MX capability optional and preserve a relay fallback on port 587. That gives you implementation flexibility while insulating you from policy reversals or account-review delays. ³⁹



From a migration-effort perspective, the easiest move is from one Linux VM-based MTA to another Linux VM-based MTA on a provider with either self-service enablement or a simple exception process. That makes **Scaleway Instances**, **AWS EC2**, and **Hetzner Cloud** the most operationally straightforward. Moving to **Scaleway Elastic Metal** is still tractable, but it introduces more infrastructure considerations. Moving to **GCP**, **Azure on the wrong subscription**, or **DigitalOcean** usually means you are not really “migrating the same design” at all; you are changing to a relay-first architecture. ⁴⁰

Recommended next steps and decision checklist

The pragmatic shortlist is:

- **Scaleway Instances** if you want the clearest current documentation and the lowest operational friction for enabling SMTP after KYC. ⁵
- **AWS EC2** if enterprise ecosystem, global footprint, and procurement familiarity outweigh the uncertainty of a request-based exception. ⁴¹
- **Hetzner Cloud** if cost efficiency matters and a one-month trust-building delay is acceptable. ⁴²

- **Akamai Cloud** if you want a global non-hyperscaler option and can tolerate the 30-day accounting requirement. ⁴³
- **Azure** only if you already have EA or MCA-E, or if shifting to a relay-based model is acceptable. ⁴⁴

The first implementation step I would take is a controlled bake-off with two lanes rather than one. Stand up a small MTA pilot on your preferred direct-to-MX host and, in parallel, configure a relay-based fallback on 587. That keeps you from blocking the migration on a provider-review queue. Because the attached file leaves budget, region, and compliance thresholds open, a two-lane test is a better use of time than trying to over-optimize the provider choice on paper. ⁴⁵

The decision checklist should be brutally simple:

- [] Do we truly need **direct external port 25**, or would authenticated relay on 587 satisfy the business need? ⁴⁶
- [] Can we tolerate provider trust-building lead time, or do we need a near-immediate enablement path? ⁴⁷
- [] Are we willing to own IP reputation and deliverability operations ourselves? ⁴⁸
- [] Is our Azure commercial model already EA or MCA-E? If not, Azure should not be treated as a “loose” port 25 provider. ²²
- [] Do we need a non-U.S. or sovereignty-oriented option? If yes, Scaleway and Hetzner become more attractive. ⁴⁹
- [] Do we need dedicated hardware or stricter tenancy isolation for reputation-sensitive workloads? If yes, evaluate Scaleway Elastic Metal rather than only VMs. ⁷
- [] Have we validated DNS, PTR/rDNS, monitoring, and rollback before making the provider decision final? ⁵⁰

Open questions and limitations

This rerun prioritized providers whose **current public documentation was both accessible and explicit**. I did **not** elevate OVHcloud, Leaseweb, Vultr, Oracle Cloud, or Alibaba Cloud into the main shortlist because I did not retrieve a comparably complete, current, and publicly accessible evidence set for all of the required dimensions during this run. That does not mean they are non-viable; it means they were not verified to the same standard here.

A few pricing and compliance pages were JS-heavy, so some fields remain incomplete. In particular, exact starter pricing was not cleanly exposed in the captured static HTML for some providers, including parts of Hetzner and Scaleway’s public-cloud SKU catalog, and Akamai’s trust-center details were not text-retrievable even though the trust portal itself was discoverable. Where that happened, I have marked the detail as unspecified rather than guessing. ⁵⁰

The bottom-line recommendation from the evidence already gathered is clear: if the design requirement truly remains **self-hosted MTA with remote SMTP port 25**, the best next evaluation targets are **Scaleway Instances, AWS EC2, Hetzner Cloud, and Akamai Cloud**, in that order unless an existing Azure EA/MCA-E relationship changes the calculus. If the business requirement can be met with **relay-based sending**, then Azure and Google Cloud become much more attractive and DigitalOcean becomes viable again — but that is a different architecture than the one implied by the attached file. ⁵¹

- 1 3 4 5 31 40 45 47 51 <https://www.scaleway.com/en/docs/instances/how-to/send-emails-from-your-instance/>
<https://www.scaleway.com/en/docs/instances/how-to/send-emails-from-your-instance/>
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- 6 <https://www.scaleway.com/en/docs/account/reference-content/understanding-support-plans/>
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